WEEK 6 · LECTURE L1 · UNIT II

Engagement Apps, Chatbots and Mobile HR

What these tools actually do, where they over-promise, and why the frontline is hard to reach.

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AFTER THIS LECTURE YOU SHOULD BE ABLE TO

What this lecture prepares you for

- Distinguish annual surveys from pulse surveys, and annual appraisal from continuous performance management.
- Evaluate HR chatbots using resolution rather than deflection.
- Explain mobile-first design principles for a frontline workforce.
- Apply goal-setting theory, feedback intervention theory, the JD-R model and Kahn's engagement conditions.

COURSE OUTCOMES

CLO 2 (engagement apps, chatbots, mobile HR).

ENGAGEMENT TOOLS

An annual survey measures; a pulse must act

Annual survey

Long, once a year, results months later. Good for trends, poor for action.

Pulse survey

A few questions, weekly or monthly, fast results. It works only if the organization visibly acts on what it hears.

Close the loop

Ask, act, then tell staff what changed because of what they said. Frequency without action breeds survey fatigue.

CONTINUOUS PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT

From an annual rating to frequent conversations

	Annual appraisal	Continuous performance management
Rhythm	Once a year	Regular check-ins and real-time feedback
Focus	Judging the past	Coaching the next step
Known problems	Recency bias, halo effects, politicized ratings	Needs managers able to hold good conversations
Example	Most large firms historically	Deloitte's redesign (Buckingham and Goodall, 2015)

EXAM LENS

Continuous systems shift the burden to manager capability. Evaluate the tool and the managers together.

HR CHATBOTS

Deflection is not resolution

Two kinds of bot

Rule-based bots follow fixed decision trees. AI bots read free text in many languages, but can answer wrongly with confidence.

The trap

Deflection counts queries a bot handled without a human; resolution counts problems actually solved. A bot can deflect 60% and resolve far less.

The design rule

Measure resolution, and give every conversation an exit to a person.

MOBILE-FIRST DESIGN

Design for the phone first, not a shrunken desktop

Few fields, big targets

Every extra field loses users on a small screen and a slow connection.

Work offline

Tolerate patchy data; save progress; sync later.

Speak their language

Vernacular text and voice, in channels people already use, such as WhatsApp.

Reach the unreachable

Feature phone users cannot use an app or a bot; for them, voice or SMS is the only route.

WHERE TOOLS OVER-PROMISE

Four promises, and what typically happens

The promise	What often happens
Pulse apps raise engagement	Low use when staff see no action on their answers
Bots cut helpdesk load	Smartphone-only staff with low literacy still raise tickets; deflection masks unresolved issues
Self-service for everyone	Staff without suitable devices are excluded
Wellbeing apps help staff	Often among the least used tools; stigma and privacy fears deter use

EXAM LENS

Tools are often bought for the employee who already has a laptop; the frontline majority bears the cost of the mismatch.

THEORY IN DEPTH · LOCKE AND LATHAM (1990; 2002)

Specific, hard goals with feedback raise performance

THE CORE IDEA

Specific, challenging goals produce higher performance than vague or easy goals.

HOW IT WORKS

Goals direct attention, energize effort, raise persistence and prompt new strategies; commitment and feedback moderate the effect.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

For complex, new tasks, learning goals work better than tough performance targets.

IN PRACTICE

A goal-tracking app helps only if goals are specific and feedback reaches the employee, not only the manager.

EXAM LENS

Name the moderators (commitment, feedback, task complexity); answers that skip them are incomplete.

THEORY IN DEPTH · KLUGER AND DENISI (1996)

Feedback can make performance worse

THE CORE IDEA

A meta-analysis of 131 studies found that about one third of feedback interventions reduced performance.

HOW IT WORKS

Feedback aimed at the self (rankings, judgments of the person) diverts attention from the task; task-focused feedback helps.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Effects vary widely with how, when and by whom feedback is given.

IN PRACTICE

A leaderboard that ranks branches or stores may lower performance; specific feedback on the task is the safer design.

EXAM LENS

This is the key counter-evidence to "more feedback is always better". Use it to critique feedback apps.

THEORY IN DEPTH · BAKKER AND DEMEROUTI (2007)

Demands drain; resources engage

THE CORE IDEA

The Job Demands-Resources model: every job has demands that cost energy and resources that build it.

HOW IT WORKS

High demands lead through strain to burnout; resources such as autonomy, support and feedback lead to engagement.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Broad and flexible, so critics argue almost anything can be called a demand or a resource.

IN PRACTICE

An app that adds logins and forms is a new demand; it must also add a resource, such as faster leave approval.

EXAM LENS

Classify each feature of an HR app as a demand or a resource; this is a strong analytical move.

THEORY IN DEPTH · KAHN (1990)

People engage when work is meaningful, safe and possible

THE CORE IDEA

Engagement is bringing your whole self to the role: physically, cognitively and emotionally.

HOW IT WORKS

Three conditions: meaningfulness (it matters), psychological safety (it is safe to speak), availability (I have the energy and means).

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Based on qualitative study of two settings; later survey measures stretched the original idea.

IN PRACTICE

A pulse survey in which staff fear their answers will be traced fails the safety condition before any question is read.

EXAM LENS

Contrast Kahn's conditions with how engagement apps measure engagement; the gap is a strong critique.

PRACTICE FOR THE END-TERM EXAMINATION

Questions to rehearse

"Engagement apps measure engagement but rarely create it." Critically evaluate using Kahn (1990) and the JD-R model. **20 marks**

A strong answer: distinguishes measurement from conditions; applies safety and availability; classifies app features as demands or resources; addresses closing the loop.

Evaluate the shift from annual appraisal to continuous performance management using goal-setting and feedback intervention theory. **20 marks**

A strong answer: applies Locke and Latham with moderators; uses Kluger and DeNisi's one-third finding; notes manager capability as the binding constraint.

Why is chatbot deflection a misleading success metric? **10 marks**

A strong answer: distinguishes deflection from resolution and proposes better measures.

CARRY THESE INTO THE EXAMINATION

Three things to remember

1. **A pulse tool works only when results are acted on and reported back**
2. **Measure chatbot resolution, never deflection alone**
3. **Design for the phone and the regional language first**

SET READINGS · FROM THE LESSON PLAN

Read for this lecture

- Bondarouk, T., Parry, E., & Furtmueller, E. (2017), the adoption and consequences sections.

COMPANION

Each set reading is explained in the matching Unit Reader on rksingh.tech/materials.

THEORY SOURCES · FOR REFERENCE

Sources for this lecture

Works named on the slides of this lecture. They are background sources, not set readings.

Bakker, A. B., & Demerouti, E. (2007). The job demands-resources model: State of the art. *Journal of Managerial Psychology, 22*(3), 309–328. https://doi.org/10.1108/02683940710733115

Bondarouk, T., Parry, E., & Furtmueller, E. (2017). Electronic HRM: Four decades of research on adoption and consequences. *The International Journal of Human Resource Management, 28*(1), 98–131. https://doi.org/10.1080/09585192.2016.1245672

Buckingham, M., & Goodall, A. (2015). Reinventing performance management. *Harvard Business Review, 93*(4).

Kahn, W. A. (1990). Psychological conditions of personal engagement and disengagement at work. *Academy of Management Journal, 33*(4), 692–724. https://doi.org/10.2307/256287

Kluger, A. N., & DeNisi, A. (1996). The effects of feedback interventions on performance: A historical review, a meta-analysis, and a preliminary feedback intervention theory. *Psychological Bulletin, 119*(2), 254–284. https://doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.119.2.254

Locke, E. A., & Latham, G. P. (1990). *A theory of goal setting and task performance*. Prentice Hall.

Sources for this lecture (continued)

Locke, E. A., & Latham, G. P. (2002). Building a practically useful theory of goal setting and task motivation: A 35-year odyssey. *American Psychologist, 57*(9), 705–717. https://doi.org/10.1037/0003-066x.57.9.705